

LECTURE 15

BUILDING AN EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION PLAN

Knowledge Area	Process				
	Initiating	Planning	Executing	Monitoring & Control	Closing
Communication Management		Plan Communication	Manage Communication	Monitor Communication	

What is Communications Management?

- Communications Management makes sure everybody gets the right message at the right time.
- 90% of a project manager's job is communication

Communication Management Processes

1. Plan communications management
2. Manage communications
3. Monitor communications

Communication in Term of Project Perspective

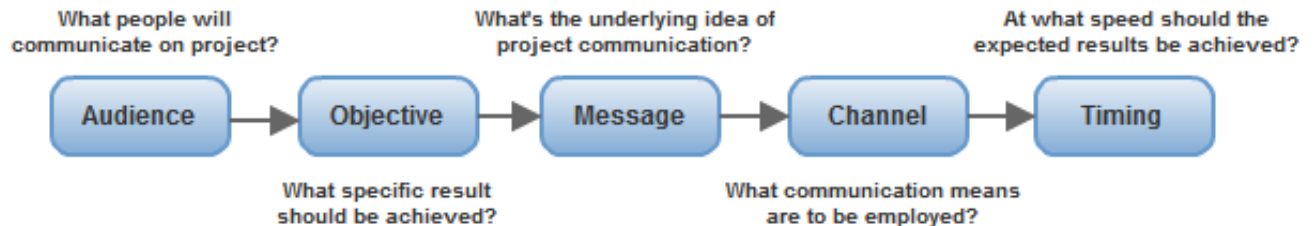
From a project perspective, communication can be looked at as either internal or external.

- **Internal communication** is the communication that takes place between project team members. Generally, this type of communication is "raw." It may involve a lot of back-and-forth discussion as plans or issues are worked out.
- **External communication** is communication between project team members and the other project stakeholders. Examples include communication with internal and external customers, other projects, and the media. Generally, this type of communication is cleaned up or otherwise prepared before being presented or sent to the receiving party.

Plan project communications management

The first step is to plan how you will manage communications on your project and across all of your stakeholders. This is done by creating a project communications management plan.

The Key Components of Communications Planning



It's important to ensure all of these factors are addressed in your plan:

Audience – this is a list of all stakeholders affected by the project. It should include team members, sponsors, customers, and other interested parties. Consider anyone impacted by the project or who influences its success.

Objective – What will be the purpose of your communications? You may use some communications for awareness, like a status report, and others that require action, such as requiring a sponsor to authorize spending, or a customer to approve project testing.

Message – What will the message be for each type of communication? This is the actual content that will be shared. Key components to be communicated include scope, schedule, budget, objectives, risks, and deliverables.

Channel – How the message will be delivered? Will it be a formal report emailed out? An informal verbal debrief during a team meeting?

Your communication plan should be detailed enough to lay out exactly what will be sent, to whom, how, when, and who is responsible. Here is a sample plan:

Deliverable Info (What)	Recipient(s) (Who)	Delivery Method(s) (How)	Schedule (When)	Who's Responsible? (Owner)
Project Information	Project Team	Sharepoint Team meetings Conference calls	As needed	Project Manager
Project Status	Project Planner PMO Director	ePortfolio Email	By 12noon every Tue. By noon every Mon.	Project Manager
Agenda/Minutes	Project Team Steering Cmte	Email Sharepoint Team meetings	Monthly	Project Manager
Timeline Update	Steering Cmte Exec. Sponsor Mtgs	Meetings Sharepoint	As needed	Project Manager
Project Updates Action Item Status	Project Manager	Team meetings Email Conference calls	As needed	Project Team
Project Risks	IITEC / Exec. Sponsor Project Steering Cmte OU Steering Cmte Project Team	Risk Document Meeting Minutes	As needed	Project Manager

Communication Management Plan Document

Involving your stakeholders in the creation of this plan is important. You need to understand their communication preferences and expectations. If you over-communicate, they may stop paying attention. But, if you under-communicate, it can lead to misunderstandings and issues.

Manage project communications

Once the plan has been created and approved, it's the project manager's job to ensure it's managed. This means that the plan needs to be reviewed and updated on a regular basis to reflect any changes to the project or its stakeholders.

The project manager also has to manage the execution of the communications management plan. This includes:

1. Collection and analysis of data.
2. Creation of messages for communication.
3. Transmission or distribution of communications.
4. Storage of any communication reports, files or documents.
5. Retrieval of any stored communications.
6. Disposal of any old communications upon project closure or a set date.

Monitor project communications

This process used to be called ‘control communications,’ but was updated in the 6th edition of the PMBOK. Despite the title change, the process is the same. It involves monitoring and controlling project communications throughout its entire lifecycle.

This may include:

- Confirming communications went out as planned.
- Confirming they were received by the proper stakeholders.
- Confirming messages were understood.
- Confirming any relevant feedback was provided to the appropriate project members.

The actual type of monitoring, including method and frequency, should be a part of the communication management plan.

Setting up ten-minute meetings

If you want to be successful in software project management, and we know you do, then you must create a plan on how you will communicate on a regular basis with your project team.

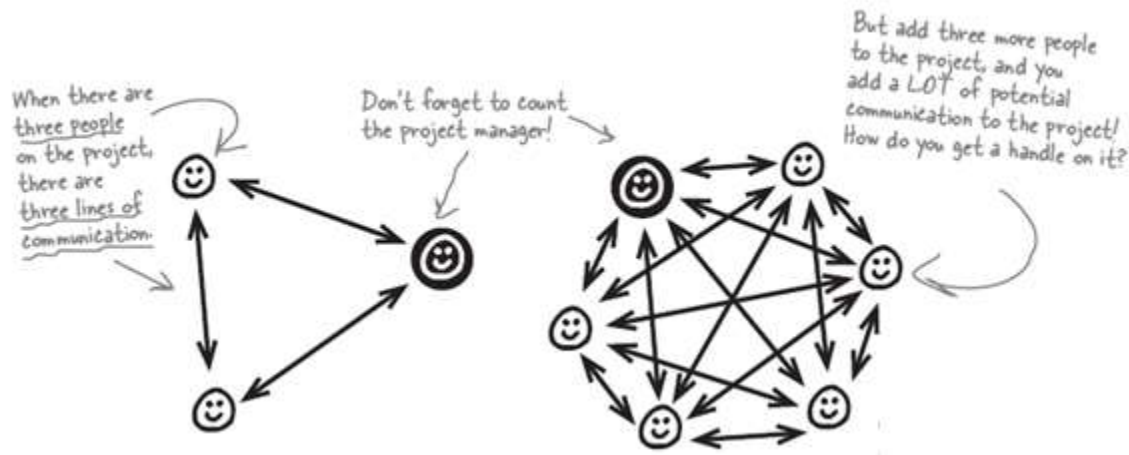
One approach that works well in software project management is the daily task meeting. The agenda of this meeting is simple and requires participants to answer just three questions:

- ✓ What did you get done yesterday?
- ✓ What must you get done today?
- ✓ What issues or problems are preventing the project from moving forward?

Ideally, this meeting lasts only 10 to 15 minutes, happens every morning, and involves only the project team.

Communication Channels

As the project manager, you have access to a trusty formula to help you determine the number of communication channels.



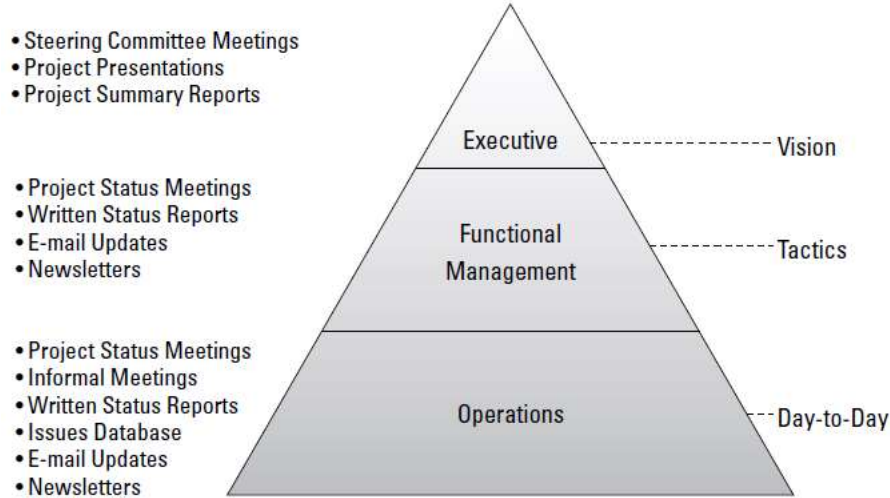
Calculate the channels of communication

This formula exists to help you understand the complexity of communication with a given number of project members:

$$\text{Number of communication channels} = N(N-1)/2$$

N represents the numbers of project members (or stakeholders) associated with the project. Remember the project manager is included here.

Defining Who Needs What Information



Defining Communication Modalities

Modality is just a fancy way of clarifying the form communication takes. Some communication should be paper-based, while other communication should be electronic. On other occasions, a formal, face-to-face presentation is the necessary modality.

Modalities for formal communication

If you're communicating to stakeholders in a formal setting, here are the types of communication modes you should employ:

- **Presentations:** Throughout your software project management career you'll likely have to get up in front of your stakeholders and present the project plan, the status of the project, or serious issues that creep into the project. Sometimes a PowerPoint presentation can help you to make your point, and at other times PowerPoint can be a distraction. The secret to a good presentation is to be prepared, speak with authority, and put your audience at ease.
- **Reports:** We once heard a project manager say, "If it's in writing, then it's formal communication." We agree with the statement, for the most part. Your reports, from status to quality control, are formal. Take time to ensure the accuracy of the data you present, not to mention your grammar.
- **Video Conference/Phone calls:** Some of your stakeholders and team members may be dispersed all over the world, so the most efficient way to communicate with them is via conference calls. When you communicate using the telephone, remember that others cannot see your facial expressions to help determine your emotions. Keep the communication clear and thorough so as to not leave a lot of room for interpretation.

- **E-mail:** E-mail can be a form of formal communication in some environments. In software project management you're dealing primarily with folks that are IT-savvy and will rely heavily on e-mail. If you're presenting formal communications through e-mail, write it just as you'd put it in a letter. Leave out the emoticons, jokes, and asides. And then save your e-mail, attachments, and any responses.

Modalities for informal communication

If you're communicating to stakeholders in an informal setting, here are the types of communication modes you should employ:

- **Ad-hoc meetings:** Quick hallway meetings, stop-and-chats, quick phone calls, and lunch discussions can be some of the most effective communications you have. The trouble with these meetings is that they can pop up unexpectedly and suck your time away. The other problem with ad-hoc meetings is that the folks you're communicating with may not follow through with the promises made during the discussion. Take care to document the discussion and then follow up with everyone involved if promises were made during ad-hoc meetings.
- **Instant messaging and text messaging:** If you have a dispersed team, this mode of communication can be especially useful. It's quick and efficient to communicate through IM or by sending text messages. The only thing you have to be concerned with is the many time zones your stakeholders may reside in. You may not want to text message someone when it's the middle of the night in his or her time zone. Some popular instant messaging programs include AIM (AOL Instant Messenger), Yahoo! Messenger, Facebook, Skype, Whatsapp and Windows Messenger.
- **Coffee talk:** Sometimes you need to get your team together for some camaraderie. It doesn't have to be over coffee, of course, but coffee and donuts, pizza, whatever, can help ease the tension of a software project, let the team vent a little about the project if they want, or just let everyone know how much you appreciate their hard work. This is about motivation and team development.